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Graduate Recruitment Team

Old Mission

London

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am applying for the Quantitative Trader – 2027 Graduate Program (August Start) in London. I am a final-year Economics student at the University of Strathclyde, graduating in summer 2027 with a predicted 2:1. Old Mission's focus on the hardest-to-price ETFs and investment-grade credit, where competitors often step back, appeals to me because pricing what others find difficult is where I most enjoy working.

Most of what I am proudest of comes down to good decisions made with incomplete information. Playing 12 poker tables at once, I based every decision on expected value and set my stakes with the Kelly criterion, keeping at least 50 buy-ins because an edge estimated from my own results could be overstated. I also finished 14th at the Irish U19 Chess Championships in 2023 and won 21 of 22 games in a simultaneous exhibition against players with an average FIDE rating of 1860. As Vice-President and then President of the Strathclyde Poker Society, I ran weekly tournaments for around 60 players on a £600 budget per semester and taught new members to use the same method to work out how many buy-ins their own win rate, variance and risk tolerance call for.

I pair that instinct with quantitative work I can defend line by line. I built a Monte Carlo option pricer in which a geometric-Asian control variate cut the standard error of arithmetic-Asian estimates by 97% at 100,000 paths, and my dissertation tests whether sovereign oil hedges make petro-currencies' oil betas smaller, kinked or one-sided on OPEC announcement days, with a pre-registered test of whether what remains is tradable. Proprietary trading appeals to me because the feedback is immediate and impartial: every decision is priced, and improving means learning faster than the market. Nearly two years of busy bar shifts alongside full-time study, and now running the drinks programme as Head Mixologist at a new 200-cover Glasgow venue, have taught me to stay accurate when speed matters.

Old Mission stands out to me because its junior traders combine disciplined decision-making, risk management and derivative pricing with research into new opportunities, and because its London business is growing, having joined the Iress UK retail service provider network as an ETF market maker in late 2025. My econometrics work in R and MATLAB has trained me to model prices from noisy data, which is what pricing an illiquid ETF from its underlying holdings demands.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Will McGowan